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CHAPTER 1

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

1.1 Previous work on hybrid agreement

Hybrid agreement is possible when there are agreement alternatives, but the controller remains the same. Corbett (2023) provides a simple example of that in English: we can say both *The family have lost everything* and *The family has lost everything*. The controller of agreement here is the word *family*, the same in both sentences, and there are two agreement alternatives: *have* and *has*. One of them is available, which is known from the lexical semantics of the noun: it can refer to a group of people. The other alternative comes from the morphosyntactic specification: the noun is singular. This is an example of hybrid number agreement, but same is possible for any other feature that requires agreement in a given language. This study focuses on gender agreement in Polish. Before the system of genders in Polish is described, this section describes Corbett's work on agreement, as it is the main basis for the study conducted later.

Corbett proposed the Agreement Hierarchy, which orders different types of agreement. This hierarchy is used to formulate the constraint visible in (1).

attributive > predicate > relative pronoun > personal pronoun

Figure 1.1: The Agreement Hierarchy (Corbett, 1979)

(1) *Constraint of the Agreement Hierarchy (to be revised)*

For any controller that permits alternative agreements, as we move rightwards along the Agreement Hierarchy, the likelihood of agreement with greater semantic justification will increase monotonically (that is, with no intervening decrease).

This constraint was created for the core instances of hybrid agreement, such as the one shown above (a lexical hybrid), and constructional mismatches, an example of which can be seen in (2).

(2) The girl and boy have been on the playground.

Both nouns in the coordination are singular, but the number in the auxiliary verb *have* agrees with the plural number suggested by the whole construction, instead of the number of the nouns within the construction.

The problem with the Agreement Hierarchy constraint in the form shown above is that it is based on “semantic justification”, when hybrid agreement can occur without one of the agreement options having a clear semantic justification. This is clear when we expand the plane of possible hybrid agreements and look at what else can trigger agreement. Alternative sources of agreement information are visible on the left of Table 1.2. The table also gives an idea of where hybrid agreement comes from: it happens whenever different sources give conflicting information about the value of a given feature.

		controller type			
		split hybrids	lexical hybrids	constructional mismatch	extraneous
Hierarchy of Agreement Sources	cell specification (1)				
	morphosyntactic specification (2)			A	
	lexical semantics (3)				
	complex nominal constructions (4)		B		
	extraneous source (5)				

Figure 1.2: Core and generalized semantic agreement

This figure includes two more examples of hybrid agreement: the split hybrid *ręka* (meaning ‘hand’) in Polish and the Norwegian *pancake* sentences with extraneous agreement information.

Polish number system used to have three possible values: singular, dual and plural. Dual is not used anymore, but the word *ręka* is one of few where the relics of dual number can be found: the form used historically as locative dual can now be used as locative singular. In modern Polish the form morphologically resembles masculine or neuter, while the noun itself is feminine. There are two conflicting sources of agreement: the morphosyntactic specification of the noun is feminine, but the specification of the (singular locative cell) can be masculine/neuter. The question then is: which of the options can be considered “semantic” agreement? One could say the feminine is semantic, because it makes it possible to track the antecedent later in the discourse, but this explanation can be considered to stretch the notion of “semantic” agreement to cover a less-than-semantic example.

On the other hand there is Norwegian “default agreement”, that is triggered when there

is no straightforward agreement controller, for instance when a sentence contains logical metonymy. As an example Corbett uses the sentence visible below.

- (3) Magnus Carlsen og Bobby Fischer hadde vær-t **super-t**.
 Magnus Carlsen and Bobby Fischer had be-pst.ptcp **super-sg.n**
 ‘Magnus Carlsen and Bobby Fischer would have been wonderful.’

Here, by *Magnus Carlsen and Bobby Fischer* speaker means *having Magnus Carlsen and Bobby Fischer play chess*. Instead of agreeing with the features suggested by the coordination, there is extraneous (default) agreement. Here the conflicting sources of agreement are: coordination of proper nouns that refer to two men and the metonymy, which triggers the “default agreement”. Here the example is considered to be more than semantic and therefore not fitting in the core semantic agreement.

Including split hybrids and examples with extraneous agreement information in the analysis forces us to expand beyond semantic agreement and consider agreement options that are less or more than semantic. This is what Corbett did by proposing generalized semantic agreement, along with the revised constraint of Agreement Hierarchy.

(4) *Revised constraint of the Agreement Hierarchy*

For any controller that permits alternative agreements, as we move rightwards along the Agreement Hierarchy, the likelihood of agreement with a greater degree of generalized semantic justification will increase monotonically (that is, with no intervening decrease).

The aim of the current paper is to see whether the Polish gender agreement pattern really fits the revised constraint of the Agreement Hierarchy. First, it is necessary to understand the system of grammatical gender in Polish.

1.2 Grammatical gender in Polish

There are multiple options of defining grammatical genders in Polish. The one chosen for this study was proposed by Mańczak (1956), where he differentiates between 5 genders: masculine personal, masculine animate, masculine inanimate, feminine and neuter. The difference between the genders is the easiest to observed when looking at appropriate forms of adjectives in the accusative case. Adjectives agree their gender with nouns and the accusative case provides the most diversity in terms of gender forms.

The example presented here comes from Mańczak (1956). There are 5 nouns and one adjective for all of them used as an example: *mężczyzna* (meaning ‘man’), *pies* (meaning ‘dog’), *stół* (meaning ‘table’), *kobieta* (meaning ‘woman’), *dziecko* (meaning ‘child’) and *dobry* (meaning ‘good’).

The table shows that each of the nouns agrees with a different set of adjective forms in the accusative singular and plural: *-ego* and *-ych* form for masculine personal, *-ego* and *-e* for

dobrego	mężczyznę	dobrych	mężczyzn	masculine personal
	psa	dobre	psy	masculine animate
dobry	stół		stoły	masculine inanimate
dobrą	kobietę		kobiety	feminine
dobrze	dziecko		dzieci	neuter

Figure 1.3: Examples of nouns in 5 grammatical genders in Polish with their agreeing adjectives

masculine animate, *-y* and *-e* for masculine inanimate, *-q* and *-e* for feminine and *-e* in both numbers for neuter.

Saloni (1976) proposed an even more elaborate system, where he talked about 9 genders (instead of one neuter there were two and additionally there were three genders for plurale tantum nouns). Such a system is, however, not necessary for the current analysis, therefore for the sake of simplicity we will adopt the 5 genders proposed by Mańczak. For ease of reference we will use for them the names that Saloni used, which are: M1 (masculine personal), M2 (masculine animate), M3 (masculine inanimate), F (feminine) and N (neuter).

1.3 Polish nouns with possible hybrid gender agreement

Corbett (2023) provides an example of gender agreement in Polish, though unfortunately that example cannot be explored further with the resources available for this study. The circumstances under which the split hybrid *ręka* 'hand' has developed to its current use are rare and there are no other nouns which can be analyzed in addition to this one. There are, however, three other categories of nouns which can be used to study hybrid gender agreement and these are described in the following subsections. This work focuses agreement with nouns and does not address complex nominal constructions, such as coordination.

1.3.1 Socially gendered nouns

Here the socially gendered nouns are defined as the nouns that refer to people and semantically involve the gender or sex of the referent. Corbett (2023) provides the German *das Mädchen* (meaning 'girl') as an example of lexical hybrids and the nouns in this group are similar to the German example. There is a number of words in Polish where the gender of the referent does not match the grammatical gender of the noun, which can lead to hybrid agreement. An example, very similar to the German one, can be found in (5).

- (5) To dziewczę jest niemożliwe! Ona w ogóle się nie uczy!
 this-N girl-N is impossible-N she in general REFL not study

'This girl is impossible! She never studies!

Here the lexical hybrid is essentially the same as the German *das Mädchen* – a noun meaning 'girl' has neuter grammatical gender. In the example we find three words agreeing with the noun: demonstrative *to* agreeing with the grammatical gender, predicate adjective *niemożliwe* agreeing with the grammatical gender and the personal pronoun *ona* in the second sentence agreeing with the semantic gender.

The socially gendered nouns are an instance of lexical hybrids: the conflicting sources of agreement are between the lexical semantics and the morphosyntactic specification of the noun. Most of those nouns refer primarily to women or girls in an expressive (often derogative) manner, but there are different combinations of conflicting values of gender. The process of choosing the nouns for this category and the combinations of conflicting genders are described in the Methodology chapter.

1.3.2 Profession nouns

In Polish some nouns referring to people holding certain job titles and functions or practising certain professions have masculine gender and there are no feminine nouns with the same meanings. These nouns are likely to be understood to only refer to men, but for a lack of better term they can be also used to refer to women. This can be seen in the examples (6) and (7).

(6) Psychiatra przepisała mi nowe leki.
Psychiatrist prescribed-F me new medicine

(7) Psychiatra przepisał mi nowe leki.
Psychiatrist prescribed-M me new medicine

The same noun *psychiatra* is used in both sentences and the only way to tell whether the referent is female or not is by looking at the predicate agreement: feminine in (6) and masculine in (7).¹

Another option to mark the referent as female is to precede the masculine noun by the word *pani*, which can be translated as 'lady' or 'madam'. It is however possible to omit it.

With recent initiatives to ensure that women are linguistically represented in all fields, there is more discussion about those masculine nouns, specifically for which of them it is difficult to create the feminine counterpart and why is it so. The current study takes advantage of this area of linguistic research by using some examples of those masculine nouns as opportunities to find hybrid gender agreement.

¹In this example the M1, M2 and M3 forms are syncretic; whenever that is the case, the M label will be used.

1.3.3 Depreciative forms of M1 nouns

In his paper Saloni points out that for all M1 nouns in plural nominative and vocative case it is possible to create an alternative form, which he calls “depreciative” (Saloni, 1988). This form is created very systematically, specifically by inflecting the noun the same way a noun of a different gender would be inflected. The M1 noun *profesor* (meaning ‘professor’) will serve as an example here. *Profesor* represents the nominative singular form of the noun. There are two options for the nominative plural form of this noun: *profesorzy* and *profesorowie*, both of these are non-depreciative. To create the depreciative form, it is necessary to look for a noun of a different gender with the same ending. For this example we can use the M3 noun *procesor* (meaning ‘processor’), which in plural nominative takes the form *procesory*. Therefore the depreciative form of the noun *profesor* is *profesory*.²

Despite the name, the purpose of using a depreciative form is not necessarily to deprecate the referent, although it has been found to be a common function of the form. Based on a corpus study, Siuda (2010) reports that the purpose of 66% depreciative forms is to express negative feelings towards the referent, 24% of the forms are used as a stylistic device, 6% are supposed to reduce the distance to the referent and 4% have a different function.

Depreciative forms can be created only for M1 nouns, but they are created by inflecting them as if they were of any other gender. The conflicting sources of agreement are the following: the morphosyntactic specification of the nominative (and vocative) plural is M2, M3, N or F, while the morphosyntactic specification of the noun is M1. This makes depreciatives the only form used in this study that represents a different controller type: a split hybrid.

1.4 Hypothesis

The aim of this study is to investigate the extent to which Corbett’s constraints of the agreement hierarchy hold on Polish data with hybrid gender agreement. The hypothesis is the following: Polish examples of hybrid gender agreement (socially gendered nouns, profession nouns and depreciative nouns) fit the simple constraint of the agreement hierarchy: there is a monotonous shift from one value of gender to another when going from attributive, through predicate to relative pronoun agreement for all kinds of nouns tested.

²In plural nominative and vocative forms are syncretic, therefore the same goes for the vocative form.

CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

2.1 Agreement sources

The corpus used for this study was the 300M subcorpus of the National Corpus of Polish (Przepiórkowski, 2012), which was parsed using Trankit (Nguyen, Lai, Veyseh, & Nguyen, 2021). The dependency trees (conforming to the Universal Dependency standard, henceforth UD) obtained this way were searched for words, which could trigger hybrid agreement: profession nouns, socially gendered nouns and depreciative forms of M1 nouns. The subsections below describe how those nouns were chosen.

2.1.1 Profession nouns

Nouns in this category came from two studies about feminitives in Polish. The first was a survey reported by Szpyra-Kozłowska (2019), where participants were asked to create feminitives from 50 masculine nouns, that in modern Polish do not have feminine counterparts at all or those counterparts are rarely used. For each noun participants had the option to give no answer. The second study was an experiment conducted by Szpyra-Kozłowska and Laidler (2022), where they tested whether certain feminitives are less accessible by asking participants to try to pronounce them. They chose 20 feminitives, which are formed from masculine nouns that end in consonant clusters such as /kt/, /tr/ or /rg/. According to Klemensiewicz (1957) adding the -ka suffix, the function of which can be to create the feminitive, makes the word difficult to pronounce. Those two studies give a list of 60 nouns in total, for which it is said to be difficult to form feminine counterparts. It is therefore likely that, if there was a female referent of a noun from this list, the masculine noun would be used, leading to hybrid agreement.

Both of the studies determine in some way which of the tested nouns have less available feminitives than others: in Szpyra-Kozłowska and Laidler (2022) those are the nouns for which there are the highest error rates in pronunciation, whereas in Szpyra-Kozłowska (2019) – the nouns for which the most people refused to propose a feminitive. Taking this approach has, however, two downsides: first, it requires an arbitrary threshold that

separates the nouns that have an easily formed feminine from the nouns for which creating the feminine counterpart is more difficult. Second, this approach significantly limits the number of nouns for analysis. Considering this, the current study used all of the nouns from the two studies on Polish femininitives.

For ease of reference, all of those nouns are called *profession* nouns, despite not all of them actually referring to professions. Meanings of all nouns are presented in Table 2.1 in the Appendix.

2.1.2 Socially gendered nouns

The nouns for this category were found using the Polish Academy of Sciences Great Dictionary of Polish available online.¹ The advanced search option allowed to search for nouns in the thematic category HUMAN AS A PHYSICAL BEING: HUMAN PHYSICALITY: SEX. This search yielded 586 results, which then had to be manually filtered to find the nouns that only refer to humans (and not, for example, abstract nouns or nouns referring to body parts) and that had incongruent grammatical and semantic gender. There were 19 nouns selected this way: 7 of them were grammatically masculine animate and referred to women, 1 was grammatically masculine inanimate and referred to women, 7 were grammatically neuter and referred to women, 2 were grammatically neuter and referred to men and 2 were grammatically feminine and referred to men. Those nouns can be found in Table 2.1 in the Appendix.

2.1.3 Depreciative forms

For this category no list of nouns was created, since the corpus was annotated and it was possible to look up the depreciative forms by checking the words' morphological description. It is possible to create depreciative forms of surnames, however these were excluded from the analysis, because there was no way of determining the referents and therefore no way of ensuring that there is hybrid agreement. Surname *Machala* found in the corpus can serve as an example: let us say that the *Machala* family bought a new car. Assuming the family consists of at least one man, the speaker can use both (8a) and (8b) to convey that information, depending on their attitude they have towards the situation: (8a) if the speaker is neutral or positive and (8b) if they are negative. However, if there are only women in the family, the speaker can only use (8b). Without the context it is unclear whether *Machały* in (8b) is used as a depreciative or simply to refer to women and therefore we cannot decide if this is an example of hybrid agreement.

- (8) a. Machał-owie kupi-li nowe auto.
Machala-pl.nom.m1.ndepr buy-3pl.m1.past new car
- b. Machał-y kupi-ły nowe auto.
Machala-pl.nom.m1.depr buy-3pl.f.past new car

¹<https://wsjp.pl/>

“Machałas bought a new car.”

Morphological analyzer Morfeusz (Kieraś & Woliński, 2017) can mark forms as surnames which made it easy to exclude them from the analysis.

2.1.4 Finding agreement sources in the corpus

The code used for extracting corpus data in this study can be found in a GitHub repository.² The general idea of how the code works is presented in this chapter.

After choosing the nouns to be searched in the corpus, it was necessary to find all of their forms and the forms’ morphological descriptions, which was done using the morphological analyzer Morfeusz. First the corpus was searched for occurrences of nouns, which could be sources of hybrid agreement. Those nouns were saved if they were in the list of gendered or profession noun forms or if they were marked as depreciative in their morphological description. To ensure that no homonyms were accidentally saved for later analysis, the morphological description of a found word was compared with the one given by Morfeusz. This way, for example, the word *premiera* was excluded if it was an instance of the lexeme *premiera*, meaning *premiere* but not if it was an instance of the lexeme *premier*, meaning *prime minister*, in the singular accusative form.

Once it was sure that the right noun was found, the dependency tree was searched for words that can agree their gender with that of the noun. This was the head of the noun (which could be an example of predicate agreement), adjectives attached to the noun (which could be examples of attributive agreement), and relative pronouns referring to the noun. Based on the UD annotation guidelines, all dependents of the word were searched for a dependency label with a subtype :RELCL, which in the UD annotation scheme mark the head of the relative clause. The relative pronoun was attached to the head of the relative clause and had a UD feature PRONTYPE=REL.³ Once the possible agreement targets were found, the data could be used to look for occurrences of gender agreement.

2.2 Listing agreement occurrences

To analyse hybrid gender agreement in the found examples, it is necessary to mark the alternative to the grammatical gender of each agreement source. For all profession nouns that alternative gender was feminine, because the only chance of hybrid agreement for those noun is when the gender of the referent is feminine. For socially gendered nouns the alternative gender was assigned depending on the lexeme.

Once the alternative gender was determined, it was necessary to exclude plural nouns for which the gender discrepancy was between feminine and neuter. This is because for all types of agreement tested here, the plural feminine and plural neuter forms of targets of agreement are syncretic, therefore there is no hybrid agreement in those cases. This

²<https://github.com/bmagdab/hybrid-agreement>

³https://universaldependencies.org/workgroups/newdoc/relative_clauses.html

happens, for instance, in (9), where in singular ((9a) and (9b)) there is a difference between the feminine and neuter forms of the word *młoda*. In plural (9c), however, the form is the same for both neuter and feminine, so hybrid agreement cannot be observed. Examples like this were therefore excluded.

- (9) a. *młod-e* *dziewczę*
 young-sg.n.nom girl.sg.n.nom
 b. *młod-a* *dziewczę*
 young-sg.f.nom girl.sg.n.nom
 c. *młod-e* *dziewczę-ta*
 young-pl.nom girl-pl.n.nom
 “young girl”

The next step was to find occurrences of different types of agreement. The predicate agreement of a given noun was found in its head on three conditions: first, dependency label between the noun and the head had to be *NSUBJ*, which is the UD label for nominal subjects. Second, the head had to be a verb that inflects for gender, which is only true for verbs annotated as past participles,⁴ active and passive participles. Third, the noun has to be in the nominative case. This condition helps filter out situations where a numeral phrase is in subject position, because then the verb does not agree with the subject – it is in 3rd person, singular and neuter form, regardless of the noun. Therefore, predicate agreement cannot be observed in those situations at all and they should be excluded.

The search was simpler with attributive and relative pronoun agreement. The only requirement for attributive agreement was that the word is an adjective, which was verified by looking for the tag *ADJ* in the morphological description of the dependent. As for relative pronouns, all of the ones found earlier were included in the analysis, unless they did not inflect for gender (which was the case, for example, for the word *gdzie*, meaning *where*).

The sentence in (10) serves as an example of the process of extracting agreement described in this chapter. The word, which could trigger hybrid agreement (but here does not, since the referent is male) is *premierem*. There are two words in the sentence that agree with this word in terms of gender: *jedynym* and *który*. All of the information saved for each instance of agreement is shown below.

- (10) Nie jest prawd-ą, że premier Jerzy Buzek
 not be.3sg.pres truth.f.sg-inst that prime.minister.sg.m1.nom Jerzy Buzek
 jest jedyn-y-m- premier-em, któr-y
 be.3sg.pres only-m1-inst-sg prime.minister.m1-sg.inst which-sg.nom.m1
 wystąpi-ł w Senac-ie.
 appear-3sg.m1.past in senate.m2-sg.loc
 “It’s not true, that prime minister Jerzy Buzek is the only one that has appeared in the Senate.”

⁴The annotation scheme used for NKJP uses the past participle label not only for past participles, but also for parts of past tense and conditional mood forms (Przepiórkowski, 2012).

		Occurrence 1	Occurrence 2
source of agreement	form	premierem	
	lexeme	premier	
	morphological description	subst:sg:inst:m1	
	grammatical gender	m1	
	other gender	f	
agreement target	form	jedynym	który
	morphological description	adj:sg:inst:m1:pos	adj:sg:nom:m1:pos
	gender	m1	m1
type of agreement		attributive	relative pronoun

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APPENDICES

Table 2.1: Socially gendered and profession nouns in Polish and their translations or definitions in English

Noun in Polish	Translation or definition in English	Category
adiunkt	someone who holds a PhD title and is employed at a scientific institution	profession
architekt	architect	profession
babochłop	a woman that resembles a man with her physicality, looks and behavior	gendered
babol	a woman that looks or behaves in a way that causes aversion in the speaker	gendered
babon	a woman, about whom the speaker feels negatively	gendered
babsko	a woman, about whom the speaker feels negatively	gendered
babsztyl	a woman, about whom the speaker feels negatively	gendered
babus	a woman, about whom the speaker feels negatively	gendered
burmistrz	mayor	profession
chirurg	surgeon	profession
chłopaczysko	a tall or big young man	gendered
chłopobaba	a man that resembles a woman with his physicality, looks and behavior (can also mean a woman that resembles a man)	gendered
ciota	a homosexual man (can also refer to a woman about whom the speaker feels negatively)	gendered
demiurg	demiurge	profession
dramaturg	playwright	profession
drań	scoundrel	profession
dupek	asshole	profession
dureń	fool	profession
dziekan	dean	profession

Continued on next page

Table 2.1: Socially gendered and profession nouns in Polish and their translations or definitions in English (Continued)

Noun in Polish	Translation or definition in English	Category
dziewczątko	a girl, whom the speaker likes or to whom they feel compassion	gendered
dziewczę	a young girl	gendered
dziewuszyisko	a girl who causes aversion or contempt in the speaker	gendered
ekspert	expert	profession
elekt	person elected in a specified post, but has not yet entered office	profession
foniatra	phoniatician	profession
ftyzjatra	pulmonologist	profession
geometra	geometer	profession
geriatra	geriatrician	profession
ginekolog	gynecologist	profession
głupek	fool	profession
herszt	ringleader	profession
inżynier	engineer	profession
jaskiniowiec	caveman	profession
jeniec	captive	profession
jeździec	rider	profession
kierowca	driver	profession
kobiecisko	expressively about a woman, augmentative, or to refer to a big woman	gendered
kobieciątko	expressively about a woman, diminutive	gendered
kobieton	a woman that resembles a man with her physicality, looks and behavior	gendered
ksiądz	priest	profession
lump	tramp	profession
magister	master (holder of a university degree)	profession
majster	foreman	profession
metalurg	metallurgist	profession
minister	minister	profession
murarz	bricklayer	profession

Continued on next page

Table 2.1: Socially gendered and profession nouns in Polish and their translations or definitions in English (Continued)

Noun in Polish	Translation or definition in English	Category
muzykolog	musicologist	profession
mędrzec	wise man	profession
naukowiec	scientist	profession
nieuk	dunce	profession
nurek	diver	profession
pacholę	a boy	gendered
pajac	clown	profession
pannisko	expressively about a young woman, augmentative	gendered
pastor	pastor	profession
pasztet	an ugly and unattractive woman	gendered
pediatra	pediatrician	profession
petent	applicant	profession
polityk	politician	profession
porucznik	lieutenant	profession
powstaniec	insurgent	profession
prefekt	prefect	profession
premier	prime minister	profession
prezydent	president	profession
proboszcz	parish priest	profession
psychiatra	psychiatrist	profession
półkownik	colonel	profession
rektor	person in charge of a university	profession
sierżant	sargeant	profession
starosta	highest administrative officer of a second-level unit of local government	profession
subiekt	salesman	profession
szklarz	glazier	profession
szpieg	spy	profession
szubrawiec	rascal	profession
upiór	phantom	profession

Continued on next page

Table 2.1: Socially gendered and profession nouns in Polish and their translations or definitions in English (Continued)

Noun in Polish	Translation or definition in English	Category
wamp	a confident, misterious, provocative and attractive woman who seduces men	gendered
widz	audience member	profession
wójt	highest administrative officer of a basic-level unit of local government	profession
zbieg	fugitive	profession